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Perspectives of Children From Refugee Backgrounds on Their Family Storytelling as a Culturally Sustaining Practice

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ABSTRACT

Foregrounding the lived experiences and voices of children from refugee backgrounds, the authors adapted culturally sustaining pedagogy and refugee critical race theory frameworks to investigate how Nepali, Somali, and South Sudanese children from refugee backgrounds whose families resettled in western New York perceive family storytelling. The authors analyzed their perspectives based on interviews of siblings following family storytelling at their houses. The authors found that the children in this study intuitively identified unique ways of family telling stories (e.g., remembering and repeated storytelling, narrative structure, and performative nuances) and internalized family storytelling as an important culturally and linguistically sustaining practice. In addition, the children made powerful connections between family and school storytelling practices (e.g., suggesting cross-cultural literacy strategies, identifying common genres, and noticing similar values taught at both settings). However, they also identified challenges to incorporating family storytelling at school, including the loss of native languages and the need for more knowledge of the stories' cultural context among peers. The authors draw implications for culturally sustaining pedagogy and research.

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Children from refugee backgrounds; culturally sustaining pedagogy; culturally sustaining practice; family storytelling

The sound of Dinka storytelling fills a cozy room in the heart of an urban neighborhood in Western New York. Six children (two girls and four boys ranging from 2 to 18 years old) listen to their father's story, one of the many he learned back in South Sudan. The couch, several chairs, and carpet are all occupied by the listeners. Two researchers, originally from Russia and China, listen to the melody of the unfamiliar language, absorb storyteller's gestures, and observe children listening. An interpreter, a South Sudanese native, is translating for the researchers and the family. As the story continues, older siblings take turns picking up and quietly engaging with an active toddler girl, who is moving from one listener to another and from the couch to the carpet and back again. The children, fluent in English, eagerly share with the researchers what they are learning from the story and how family stories are different from those told in school. A 6-year-old boy emphasizes that he likes his father's stories because they can help him learn more Dinka. "I want to learn Dinka and become the president of South Sudan to help my people," he proudly says.

This vignette describes a family storytelling session and the follow-up group interview with children from a South Sudanese refugee family resettled in an urban neighborhood of western New York.

"Storytelling is one of the oldest human art forms. Ancient cultures maintained their histories and culture of self through the stories they told and retold" (Ladson-Billings, 2013, p. 41). Today, though understudied in education (Hibbin, 2016), storytelling continues to maintain cultural practices and traditions over time, socialize children into their cultures, and aid their overall development (Barton & Barton, 2017). Within culturally heterogeneous societies that resettle people from refugee backgrounds, diverse storytelling practices continue to intertwine histories, cultures, and ways of thinking into intergenerational learning of modern families (Heath, 1982; McCabe, 1997). The reproduction

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of diverse cultures and histories heavily relies on the agency of children (Jirata & Simonsen, 2014). However, research rarely places children at the center of storytelling investigations (Jirata & Simonsen, 2014). To address this gap in the literature, this study explores how children from diverse refugee backgrounds perceive storytelling experiences upon resettlement in a new country.

It is important to understand how children from refugee backgrounds internalize family storytelling and if they perceive it as a vital cultural practice for multiple reasons. First, storytelling diversity within families from refugee backgrounds is often in conflict with schooling that tends to promote the dominant culture through explicit and implicit curricula (Hollins, 2015; Long, Souto-Manning, & Vasquez, 2016). At school, children from refugee backgrounds are “being asked to lose or deny their languages, literacies, cultures, and histories in order to achieve” (Paris & Alim, 2017, p. 1). In other words, to be more successful in school, children might feel pressured to abandon their own culture. This pressure places diverse refugee cultures at risk for largely irreversible extinction (i.e., assimilation) (Haller, Portes, & Lynch, 2011). Studying how children from refugee backgrounds view family storytelling helps us understand how they respond to these pressures and maintain cultural practices. Second, children from refugee backgrounds operate between family stories they hear at home and contrasting stories about refugees that permeate elsewhere. Much of the research (McBrien, 2005), public discourse (Kisiara, 2015), children’s literature (Strekalova-Hughes, Wang, & Lewman, 2018), and media (Devlin & Grant, 2017) centralizes stories about refugees as traumatized, vulnerable, and voiceless. These dominant discourses deny the complexity of identity and tie refugee stories to their protective legal refugee status (Strekalova-Hughes, Bakar, Nash, & Erdemir, 2018; Strekalova-Hughes, Nash, & Erdemir, 2017). Children’s voices about family storytelling can provide powerful counternarratives to external stories surrounding refugee families.

This study investigates children’s perspectives on storytelling in three refugee communities (Nepali, Somali, and South Sudanese) resettled in the United States. Our investigation was guided by the overarching question of how children from refugee backgrounds perceive storytelling. In particular, we were interested in the following research questions: (1) How do children from refugee backgrounds perceive family storytelling as a culturally sustaining practice? and (2) How do they perceive family storytelling and school storytelling experiences? We draw implications from culturally sustaining practices within the families to culturally sustaining pedagogy at school (Paris, 2012; Paris & Alim, 2017).

Theoretical and conceptual perspectives

Two conceptual perspectives informed the design, data analysis, and interpretation in our study. First, culturally sustaining pedagogy (Paris, 2012; Paris & Alim, 2017) guides us to explore if family storytelling is a cultural practice that children from refugee backgrounds want to sustain and, if so, look for culturally situated features that could inform culturally sustaining pedagogy. Second, refugee critical race theory (Strekalova-Hughes et al., 2018, 2017) foregrounds the voices of children from refugee backgrounds and provides a critical analytical lens specific to refugee experiences.

Culturally sustaining pedagogy

Cultural practices are “dynamic, shifting, and ever-changing” (Paris, 2012, p. 95). “Culturally sustaining pedagogy seeks to perpetuate and foster—to sustain—linguistic, literate, and cultural pluralism as part of the democratic project of schooling” (p. 93). The purpose of culturally sustaining pedagogy at school is to sustain cultures “in both the traditional and evolving ways that are lived and used by contemporary young people” (p. 95). This stance is particularly important for studying children from families who resettle in new communities under refugee status. Children from refugee backgrounds live dynamic cultures that evolve differently in countries and communities of origin than in transition associated with displacement. For example, some children may be born in refugee

camps or in countries of resettlement after their families spent years in refugee camps away from the country of origin (Strekalova-Hughes, 2017; Strekalova-Hughes & Wang, 2017).

Often, schooling upon resettlement essentializes children's academic achievement through assimilation and does little to prevent the loss of "community cultural and linguistic practices if they were to succeed in American schooling" (Paris, 2012, p. 94). The purpose of culturally sustaining pedagogy is to value and maintain each culture within a multilingual and multicultural society by democratically including and intentionally sustaining all of its cultures in the classroom as a part of the better collective whole. Before we develop culturally sustaining pedagogies for children from refugee backgrounds, we need to investigate what cultural practices continue to be an important part of their lived environments and how their cultural repertoires evolve (Gutiérrez & Rogoff, 2003). Specifically, we need to see if family storytelling remains a valuable cultural practice in changing environments. We adopt this theoretical perspective to explore children's perspectives on cultural importance of family storytelling and cultural aspects of this intergenerational literacy practice.

Refugee critical race theory

Rooted in critical race theory in education (Ladson-Billings & Tate, 1995) and the long history of work by scholars of color (e.g., Bell, 1980, 1992; Delgado & Stefancic, 2001), refugee critical race theory (RefugeeCrit) (Strekalova-Hughes et al., 2018, 2017) focuses on legally and economically influenced educational experiences of children and families under refugee status. RefugeeCrit poses that "refugee narratives are often legally and economically chained to their protective status" and "need careful unpacking to remove the layers created to fit into the legal and material access mechanisms" (Strekalova-Hughes et al., 2017). For example, determinations of refugee status by the United Nations require an agent's "evaluation of the applicant's statements" that convincingly demonstrate "well-founded fear of being persecuted" (United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, 2011, p. 11). Then, stories of violence, fear, and need for help may be used beyond their intended legal purpose (Strekalova-Hughes et al., 2018). For example, resettling organizations often exploit refugee stories to gain asylum to increase donations (Kisiara, 2015). These public exploitations become a hashtag of refugee representation in public discourse and are not necessarily the central aspect of the complex, culturally and historically situated, identities that families want to sustain and pass on to their children.

RefugeeCrit asks researchers to centralize agential voices and stories of children and families from refugee backgrounds to gain perspectives on their lived experiences and complex identities that counter the dominant discourses tied to a unifying refugee status. Rather than focusing on the refugee experience itself, we center family storytelling as funds of knowledge (González, Moll, & Amanti, 2006), honoring and valuing the practices that were important to families and communities before displacement and might be important to the future generations after resettlement. We frame the study by interpreting context of refugee storytelling from a critical perspective and focusing on children's perspectives on stories and storytelling practices that their families choose to sustain to provide counternarratives to external outsider stories about refugees.

Relevant literature

Storytelling and culture

Family storytelling is a form of intergenerational learning and literacy practice. Intergenerational learning is a "transmission of beliefs and practices and modeling of behaviors from generation to generation" (Gadsden & Hall, 1996, p. 4). Intergenerational literacies are the "pathways and patterns of literacy learning and practices in families over time and multiple generations" (Gadsden, 2008, p. 163). Intergenerational literacy practices, including storytelling, are important to study among populations who cross cultures, languages, and societal structures. Storytelling practices evolve as they follow

people who inherit them (Perry, 2008). Currently, we know very little about how children from refugee backgrounds continue to learn from this form of intergenerational literacy (Perry, 2008). Surprisingly, research pays little attention to children's perceptions of storytelling in general (Hibbin, 2016; Jirata & Simonsen, 2014) and children from refugee backgrounds in particular.

If children from refugee backgrounds value and engage in intergenerational storytelling, we need to know its specific cultural underpinnings to develop adequate culturally sustaining pedagogical practices upon resettlement. In general, research offers great insight into diversity of culturally situated features of storytelling that represent valuable "ways of acquiring knowledge" and "displaying knowledge" (Heath, 1982, p. 73). McCabe (1997) studied storytelling in African American, Japanese, and Russian cultures to reveal unique structural differences in stories they tell. Eder (2007) explored storytelling in the Navajo culture to highlight the great importance of context of storytelling "in maintaining the integrity of Navajo culture." Specifically, features such as "who is telling the story, the season in which it is told, and the manner in which it is told" are uniquely different and important for anyone attempting to curricularize Navajo storytelling (p. 280). In African Zulu stories, songs are one of the distinctive features that are "vital in the interaction that takes place between the performer and her audience" (Ntuli, 2010, p. 216).

Children internalize verbal and nonverbal family norms of participating in literacy practices (Cochran-Smith, 1985). Children's stories and personal narratives are intertwined with the cultures in which they live (Tsai, 2017). Minami and McCabe (1991) found that Japanese children's narratives echoed essential features of haiku, a literary form commonly practiced in Japan. Tsai (2017) found that Taiwanese children's stories aligned with manners of living in culturally different communities. In that study, though children from Kinmen used plentiful sensory details in their stories (e.g., what they saw, heard, felt, and thought), Taipei children depicted constant movement, action, and hurry. These storytelling features closely resembled cultural elements within their respective communities. Children as representatives of specific cultural backgrounds can serve as keys into the evolving and dynamic cultural ways of telling stories. As a result, there is a need to study how children from refugee backgrounds perceive storytelling as a part of their transforming lives (Perry, 2008).

Cultural tensions and storytelling

Research on refugee storytelling suggests that such literacy practices are "closely connected with issues of power and marginalization" (Perry, 2008, p. 323). Throughout the history of the United States, school practices reflected the cultural "norm" that worked to "legitimize cultural domination and to intimidate and discredit groups posing a threat to the status quo" (Hollins, 2015, p. 33). From the colonial period marked by attempts to "educate" diverse Native American populations out of their cultures, there have been multiple examples of populations that were led to "abandon their own cultural practices in favor of the national culture" (Hollins, 2015, p. 35). For example, African American, Chinese, Italian, and Japanese populations have experienced legislative measures that targeted their economic and cultural opportunities in the country through policies in the education system.

"Through sameness of language is produced sameness of sentiment and thought; customs and habits are molded and assimilated in the same way, and thus in process of time the differences producing trouble would have been gradually obliterated" (United States Office of Indian Affairs, 1887, p. XX). Such official documents highlight that cultural practices closely associated with language historically have been under pressure compared to practices less connected to language. As a literacy practice, family storytelling of marginalized communities continues to face these pressures. Storytelling diversity of children from refugee backgrounds is missing from an average classroom in the United States (Heath, 1982) that focuses on "teaching a child from a non-European culture to tell European-style stories" (McCabe, 1997, p. 469).

Culturally sustaining pedagogy (Paris & Alim, 2017) aims to counteract assimilationist traditions in schools and has already started to inspire research that offers culturally sustaining classroom practices responsive to its students (e.g., Nash, Panther, & Arce-Boardman, 2017). To inform this

line of research, we examine children's voices demonstrating how they respond to tensions between family and school storytelling and how they identify cultural features of family storytelling that are important to maintain.

Methodology

Aiming to understand refugee children's perspectives of their family storytelling, we investigated these two specific questions: (1) How do children from refugee backgrounds perceive family storytelling as a culturally sustaining practice? and (2) How do they perceive family storytelling and school storytelling experiences? We employed semistructured group interviews (Brinkmann, 2018) to intentionally focus on how children from refugee backgrounds describe their views and experiences of family and school storytelling and allow fluid follow-up opportunities on "whatever angles are deemed important" in the context of this phenomenon (p. 579).

Participants

For the study, we recruited families from refugee backgrounds who told stories at home. We identified three families from each target country of origin (Nepal, Somalia, and South Sudan) for a total number of nine families. After obtaining informed consent during the initial meeting, we visited each family twice to record their regular storytelling at home and conducted group children/sibling interviews following each storytelling session (27 visits total). We relied on interpreters who were prominent members of the respective cultural communities throughout each step of the process.

Across families, 34 children participated in storytelling sessions and consequent group interviews. The majority of our participants were age 3 to 8 years because we recruited families who had at least one child attending an early childhood educational setting. Occasionally, an older sibling (adolescent) would respond to or build upon their younger siblings' responses. Infants and toddlers present during sibling interviews generally were playing and engaging with their family members rather than participating in the interview. We only report the number of children participating in storytelling sessions and interviews, not the total number of children in each family. Each cultural community consisted of three family clusters. Nepali storytelling sessions involved three children in the first family and four children in the second and third families. In total, 11 children (six girls and five boys) participated in Nepali storytelling sessions and children interviews. Somali storytelling sessions and children interviews had one child in the first family and three children in the second and third families. In total, seven children (three boys and four girls) participated in Somali data collection. South Sudanese storytelling session and children interviews involved eight children in the first family, six children in the second family, and two children in the third family. In total, 16 children (eight boys and eight girls) participated in the South Sudanese data collection.

Data collection and analysis

We conducted in-depth semistructured interviews with our participants. Data sources consisted of 18 video-recorded interviews with the children that followed stories told by their family members (ranging from 15 minutes to 1 hour). After adults told a story, we asked children questions related to that particular story, questions about the larger purpose of storytelling, and, finally, questions about experiences of storytelling practices between family and school. Sample protocol questions included, "What does this story teach you?" "Why do parents tell you stories?" "How are stories same or different between home and school?" and "Would you share family stories at school? Why?" Follow-up questions included, for example, "What would your peers think about the story?" for the children who wanted to share family stories at school.

Theoretical perspectives of culturally sustaining pedagogy (Paris, 2012; Paris & Alim, 2017) and refugee critical race theory (Strekalova-Hughes et al., 2018) recursively shaped our coding scheme for the child interview transcripts. The content analysis of the stories and adults' meaning making of storytelling were not the primary focus of this article and are reported elsewhere (Wang & Strekalova-Hughes, 2018) to keep the focus on the children's voices rather than the stories themselves. Translations of these stories, however, informed our cross-referencing of children's understanding and internalization of storytelling. It is worth mentioning that stories the adults chose to share within families included, for example, traditional mythical and animal stories, stories of national heroes and historic events, and stories of families back in their native lands, rather than stories about experiences related to the legal protective refugee status. The two researchers with uniquely different cultural and experiential backgrounds (i.e., Russian and Chinese backgrounds, different educational experiences, and varying years in the United States) negotiated meaning throughout the process of emergent coding. Our constant comparative analysis (Lincoln & Guba, 1985) brought forward and made noticeable themes related to cultural underpinnings of family storytelling and possible aspects of storytelling practices that can inform culturally sustaining pedagogy for this diverse population.

Findings

In looking for answers to our two research questions, we organized findings into two major parts: children's perceptions about storytelling as a culturally sustaining practice and children's perceptions about family storytelling vs. school storytelling. We share our findings below before moving to discuss and interpret them.

Children's perception about storytelling as a culturally sustaining practice

Cultural grounding of family storytelling

Children in this study intuitively noticed the unique cultural ways of storytelling—remembering and repeated storytelling—through which their families sustain culture at home. Children across the three cultural communities noticed the importance of remembering stories within families and how different this practice of remembering was from what they see at school. For example, a South Sudanese son pointed out, “I think it's different because he [father] tells us *remembering* what he knows and at school we read a story off a sheet of paper. It's not the same because it's not paper and he tells it from memory.” A Somali 6-year-old boy hypothesized that the teacher reads the stories because she does not remember them, “Because at school teachers read books, they can't memorize.” The importance of remembering and telling from memory appeared so important that a Somali 9-year-old daughter went further. She tried to figure out how to help teachers share their family stories at school to compensate for their lack of memory. “I could write it [story from home] on a piece of paper and ask teacher to read it,” she proposed.

More importantly, children perceived remembering stories as a prerequisite to being able to transmit them to the next generation. Although children across several families expressed the desire to tell family stories to their own children, they were unsure whether they would be able to maintain family traditions and tell the same stories to their own children. For example, a Nepali 14-year-old girl shared that she would like to tell her father's stories to her own children. However, her intention was contingent upon remembering the stories for years to come. She said, “If I have good memory, I will [share stories with my own children].”

Children in the study also highlighted repeated storytelling as a culturally sustaining way of sharing stories within their family. Several children shared their favorite stories in their mother tongue. They credited their ability to retell stories to hearing them repeatedly. Even the children who perceived their English competency to be higher retold their favorite stories in their mother tongue. For example, one 6-year-old Somali boy identified his English as better than his Somali. However,

when we asked him to share a favorite story, he proceeded to tell one in Somali. “How do you remember the story?” we asked. He readily shared, “Because mom told me a lot of times.” His thoughts about the culturally sustaining way of repeated storytelling were echoed by children from Nepali and South Sudanese communities.

Culturally sustaining purpose of storytelling

Children described family storytelling as adults’ way of teaching them about life and sharing this learning forward. For example, a 6-year-old Somali boy, among others, suggested that his mother tells them stories “because she wants us to learn.” Children perceived the nature of the learning to be moral lessons in the stories and family/cultural histories captured in the stories. Across 18 stories and three communities (Nepali, Somali, and South Sudanese), children shared their understanding of what is a “good or bad thing to do” based on the stories they heard. For example, “Don’t try to trick anyone; if you try to trick someone, you can die,” “Swim in the water by yourself instead of making someone else do it for you,” “Don’t cheat,” “Don’t be a follower.... Be a leader,” “Calling other people stupid won’t make you feel smart,” “Don’t judge people by their looking” and so on. In addition to learning moral lessons, children identified the outcome of learning the history of their own cultures and practices associated with traditional spirituality (e.g., “not to leave the baby in the sacred place”). At times, the children had different interpretations of the stories and engaged in negotiation and expansion of the meaning with their siblings. Every story had an array of subtle and more evident meanings, some of which were more accessible to children than others, often based on age and mother tongue knowledge level (see more on language below). According to the children, the moral teachings were encapsulated in stories that were humorous and highly entertaining.

Beyond accessing cultural meaning within stories, children applied those meanings in the new cultural contexts. For example, the cultural value of generosity and hospitality transcultured into a U.S. urban core community for a 6-year-old Somali boy. After listening to the mother’s story about a traveler who stopped by a stranger’s house on his journey to see a doctor, he suggested that if a hungry traveler knocked on his door in Buffalo and asked to come in, he would be a welcomed guest. If the traveler was “cool and poor” and not a “hyena,” he would let him in and feed him. This value of greeting and welcoming strangers who need help stood out as the opposite of the widespread “stranger danger” cultural narrative in the United States. The value of hospitality and generosity prevailed in this learner’s judgment of the situation. Eight siblings from a South Sudanese family shared another example of applying story lessons to life. The father told them a story about a family where every member, including children, contributed to the livelihood of the family, taking nothing for granted. The older daughter said that this family is “like our family because there are a lot of children” and recognized the importance of doing chores to keep up the house. Other siblings echoed the moral lessons of working hard, sharing responsibility, and contributing to the family. They explained that the story comes to life in their everyday being as a family. In addition, this moral transcultured into the context of school. One of the older siblings shared,

Some people are not like how we are taught. Like their parents would teach them something different. Like you can go to school if you want to.... For me, I don’t have a choice. I have to go to school.... We have to go to school because my dad says that he worked hard for us to get good education.

This work ethic came from the sense of shared responsibility and mutual gratitude captured in the story and everyday conversations. The children applied these moral lessons to their everyday lives inside and outside of their homes in the context of resettlement.

In addition to applying lessons from stories to their immediate lives, children perceived stories as a way to preserve and share cultural knowledge across generations. For example, a Somali daughter noted that her mother “want(s) me to share it [story] with the world like to tell some other people, so they tell more people.” This example highlights children’s awareness of storytelling practice as a way to transmit learning beyond one’s personal enrichment. Another child highlighted the

intergenerational aspect of this learning across time. He noted, “She [mother] wants us to share [these stories] in the future.”

Storytelling as a language sustaining practice

Children in the study identified storytelling as a vehicle to sustain family language. For example, when asked which language is preferred for storytelling, a Somali 9-year-old girl shared, “I like it [storytelling] in Somali because it will teach me how to speak in Somali.” Another participant, a 6-year-old Somali boy shared that despite his better understanding of English, he preferred stories in Somali, “Because I like the words” and “So I can be better.” The purpose of mastering native languages transcended beyond sustaining language for the language’s sake. Children articulated the purpose of language as a medium to connect to others from the same linguistic background in the immediate linguistic community. For example, a girl wanted to speak Somali to communicate with neighbors who come by when her mother is not home “so I can tell her what they said.” Another purpose of sustaining language through storytelling aimed at communicating beyond the immediate resettlement community. For example, a participant shared the need to connect to family that lives far away. Specifically, she needed to learn Somali to write to her brother in Washington, D.C., and send letters to “my other family members so they can read it.”

Another purpose of maintaining language through family storytelling was highly connected to cultural identity and possibility of repatriation. A 7-year-old South Sudanese boy articulated his urge to learn and maintain the mother tongue, “I want to learn Dinka and become the president of South Sudan to help my people.... I want to stop wars and make it easier for people.” This high-stakes rationale for sustaining the languages connected to their ability to successfully master and maintain linguistic proficiency in the language of their families.

Some children shared the challenge of getting to the meaning of family stories due to language. For example, a South Sudanese boy shared his inferencing processes listening to his father’s stories:

When he tells us story you try to connect the dots to get what he is saying. In English, it’s much easier to understand because I know more English.... It’s really hard to connect the dots and analyze why.

He shared the additional cognitive work that is required for him when listening to stories at home. In rare cases, the loss of meaning was so significant that the stories were unrecognizable when retold by the listener. When the language of storytelling is not accessible, so is the meaning of the stories. The children showed agency in inventing strategies to help each other understand the stories collectively. When siblings knew the word or understood more of the story, they shared with each other.

Children’s perception about family storytelling vs. school storytelling

Sense making across contexts

Children agentially made connections between family and school storytelling. Specifically, they found similarity in genres, identified common moral lessons, noticed similar purposes of storytelling, and shared examples of a new culture’s influences on their family storytelling practices. For example, a South Sudanese high schooler thought that some stories at home were similar to stories at school:

We read I think a Greek mythology book about facing demons and monsters. So I think it kind of similar to the one [South Sudanese story] about sea creatures taking the father and how the son tries to save the father from the people under the water.

Although Greek mythology might have been equally “culturally irrelevant” to all peers in his Western New York public school classroom, he readily drew connections between the two texts and identified the genre similarity—fantasy. A 9-year-old Somali girl drew connections between the common moral lessons of stories she heard at home and at school. She shared that her mother’s Hyena and Fox story teaches “not to trust someone you really don’t know.” Then, she thought of a story from school that teaches a similar moral lesson: “Red Riding Hood, when she trusts the fox [wolf] that she is her grandmother.” Several children also found that family and school stories are

similar “because they both tell lessons.” Specifically, “It’s very similar because they sometimes teach things the kids shouldn’t be doing and things we don’t do that we should be doing.” A South Sudanese middle schooler told a story from school that had the same purpose as family stories, “telling the moral”:

The ones we read at school are similar because they both have a moral.... Like one, there was a prince in Asia, a king, that had lots of sons that would take over after him, so he asked all his sons to make something for him. And the one son made two rice cakes and other sons made like very special things from different countries and he asked his wife and his kids to make rice cakes in their yard instead of travel to a different country. And the king chose him because instead of going to different countries he used the things that he had like all kind of resources to make the two rice cakes.

The boy identified the moral he could relate to, “It’s like use the natural resources instead of using other countries’ resources.”

Children also used the same cross-cultural strategies to access meaning in stories from home and school. For example, a South Sudanese boy shared a comprehension strategy he used when engaging with storytelling at home and school, “When my father is speaking Dinka and when I am reading a book I’m kind of connecting the dots as to why the things are happening and to why a person does what they do and stuff like that.” The child credited the same cognitive processes of “connecting the dots” or inferencing for his ability to access and interpret the meaning of stories between the two contexts (home and school). Nepali siblings shared how they use the same strategy, context clues, to decode unknown words at school and at home. The children shared how they interpret unfamiliar words while listening to father’s storytelling:

Some words we have never even heard of [in Nepali]. We speak English to each other. I don’t know 100% Nepali.... “Bamboo” is hard because we don’t hear this word a lot around the house. We don’t talk about that thing often.... We use context clues. The word before that and after that helped us like know what that means.

In addition, children integrated some aspects of the school culture into the literacy practices at home. For example, a 6-year-old Somali boy enjoyed “Superman books and Ironman books, and ... culture books and the dog books.” A Nepali 4-year-old girl enjoyed the Cinderella story. Some of the family storytelling responded to the new context. For example, the Somali boy who enjoyed Superman stories also mentioned that some of his favorite stories are bilingual Somali and English books that his mother and he picked from a book club. Interestingly, the culturally situated media permeated children’s lives and storytelling practices as well. For example, a Somali boy shared that he owns “the TV book.” When we asked to tell us more about this book, “The movie that we have upstairs.... I watched a movie and then saw a T-shirt on little kids [at school]” and now “we have a new book. The TV book.” Other media influence examples included a Nepali 8-year-old girl who mentioned that they read “the cartoon story” at school and a 14-year-old Nepali girl who mentioned, “You read the story first and then we watch the movie together.”

Storytelling practices at school

Children readily described stories they encountered at school. For example, a Somali daughter shared, “Sometimes we listen to Goldilocks ... and the Poison Apples.” This girl of color who wears a hijab was referencing school stories that depict White lead female characters who are often blond and/or fair skinned, including “the fairest of them all”—Snow White. The stories she heard at home featured people who shared her phenotype and cultural heritage. A Nepali brother and sister also shared how storytelling plots differed between family and school. Specifically, the father often told them stories about the history of Nepali people (similar to South Sudanese families in the study), whereas the school stories were about something they found less relevant. “Like when your parents tell you stories, it’s interesting and they talk about the *past*, they take our attention,” whereas teachers read about things “like *pets*.” The brother described implications of the past versus pets dichotomy—at home he listened to the stories attentively, while at school he was “goofing around” during the pet stories. Somali families in the study had more stories that featured animals than Nepali families, and

a Somali boy shared how much he enjoyed “dog books” at school. Thus, conclusions about levels of connections children make with texts at school may differ based on specific intersectional cultural and experiential backgrounds.

Children also noticed differences in how teachers tell stories at school. The language of stories emerged as an obvious drastic difference between school and family storytelling. Beyond the language itself, children were picking up some more nuanced aspects of storytelling: “The language and *the way they are speaking*. When my mom speaks, it’s different.” One of the examples to illustrate this difference in the way teachers speak are performative nuances. A Nepali girl shared, “My mom talks like normal [not acting out different characters] and they [teachers] talk like making noises.” Specifically, when elaborating on this “big difference” in storytelling practices, she recalled the “different noises” during a story about Lion and Mouse at school, “She [teacher] makes sounds. The lion makes big noise and mouse makes little voice.” In addition to the animated delivery of stories that appeared to be more common at school than at home, children were picking up differences in narrative structures between the contexts. For example, “When parents tell us stories, they go deep into it,” providing many details about the story, while at school, “they just stop.” Some children noticed that teachers also interrupt the flow of the story by asking questions, “Every 10 minutes she [teacher] stops reading and asks questions.”

Peer acceptance

Interestingly, almost every child participating in the study expressed the desire to share home stories at school and articulated optimism about their peers’ reception of the stories. There were rare exceptions. One child hesitated in sharing because she was “shy.” Another child thought that the peers already knew the story she wanted to share. Children from all three communities overwhelmingly expressed confidence that their peers would enjoy their home stories if shared at school. Several reasons emerged as the rationale for this confidence. Primarily, children thought that their family stories were undeniably entertaining. When asked follow-up questions about why their peers would like family stories, the majority of the children thought that peers would find their favorite stories funny and would laugh. For example, a Somali 9-year-old girl said, “I think they will like it because it’s really funny.” Her 6-year-old brother echoed, “Because the funny man was funny.” A South Sudanese boy thought his peers might like the story “because it’s very interesting and has a lot of details.” They also might like it “because it’s history.” Some children thought classmates would enjoy their family stories due to their educational value. Friends “might learn a lesson to not trust people you don’t really know,” predicted a 6-year-old Somali boy.

At the same time, none of the children had shared family stories at school by the time of the study. The examples of how peers would perceive their storytelling remained hypothetical. The learners wanted to share, but when asked how they would tell the story, the majority chose English to accommodate the teacher’s and peers’ primary language (e.g., “I would tell them in English because they do not know Somali”). Language differences emerged as a strong perceived barrier in sharing stories at school. “If I can say some Somali words in English to them, I could then [share the stories at school]. It’s hard to pronounce it.” This sentiment echoed throughout every community in the study. For example, a Nepali girl was excited to share the family story, yet the language prevented her from doing so, “Definitely I will [share this story at school], this is a cool one, but it’s hard to translate. It’s hard to translate every single word into English.”

Beyond the language, children brought to light critically important aspects of storytelling, such as shared context. For example, “If I translate good, it might be funny. It’s still not gonna be as funny as if I told it to like Nepali people.” Although the language was important in being able to share storytelling from home at school, it was not the only prerequisite: “Language of course, but it won’t be exact same *setting* and you have to change the examples, you have to change *the way* you say it.” The children were highlighting the importance of way of telling and knowing the context. For example, if a king in the family story was American, instead of Nepali, “It would be much better, it’s just gonna be much easy for other people because he is American and they

know about it, but this thing, they never heard about it before so it's gonna be strange a little bit."

Discussion

In this study, we investigated children's perspectives about storytelling in three resettled refugee communities (Nepali, Somali, and South Sudanese). Below we discuss and interpret findings to our research questions before moving to implications for research and practice.

Family storytelling as a culturally sustaining practice

Our findings revealed interesting ways how children view storytelling as a culturally and linguistically sustaining practice in refugee communities.

First, the children in this study noticed the culturally grounded nature of their family stories and unique ways of telling stories that may distinguish family storytelling from school. The children pointed out the narrative structure (e.g., level of detail) and performative aspects (e.g., "normal" vs. "little voice" for a mouse and "big voice" for a lion) that distinguished storytelling between family and school. These narrative structures and performance differences may be just as vital to children's storytelling traditions as in Zulu (Ntuli, 2010) and Navajo (Eder, 2007) cultures. As such, they would be important to target in culturally sustaining pedagogical practices that intend to serve children from refugee backgrounds that represent diverse cultural and experiential backgrounds. Aligning with previous research on cultural aspects of storytelling (McCabe, 1997; Minami & McCabe, 1991; Tsai, 2017), the children also perceived remembering and repeated storytelling as ways of telling stories that need maintaining. Several participants shared how repeated storytelling allowed them to practice native languages and reengage with meaning making from the same stories, highlighting its language sustaining potential. As some children discussed, remembering had serious implications for their ability to transmit cultural values within stories to others and across time (e.g., "If I have a good memory, I will"). In addition, the way stories are told can nurture important cognitive processes that are culturally situated (Hollins, 2015). At home, children are socialized into cultural practices that engage their minds differently than when they look at pictures and listen to teachers' read-alouds. In absence of illustrations and having the high stakes of remembering, children may engage different and more complex cognitive mechanisms to grasp and retain meaning.

Second, the children internalized culturally sustaining purposes of family storytelling, applied lessons from stories to their lives, and aspired to carry storytelling forward and pass it on to their own children. Paris and Alim (2017) suggested that culturally sustaining pedagogy grows from the cultural ways of being that communities and their youth want to sustain. If children see no value in learning from and sharing stories, they will likely discontinue the cycle of intergenerational transmission of cultural values and practices within literacy events such as storytelling. In our findings, we moved closer to "contemporary understanding of culture as dynamic and fluid, while also allowing for the past and present to be seen as merging, a continuum, or distinct, depending on how young people and their communities live race/ethnicity, language, and culture" (Paris & Alim, 2017, p. 8). Our participants viewed storytelling as a valuable cultural practice that needs sustaining. What children did not appear to focus on are stories related to their family's legal protective refugee status. While external stories about refugees are often attached to their protective legal status and experiences (Hope, 2008; Strekalova-Hughes et al., 2018, 2017), the stories children wanted to pass on to their own families were the highly entertaining and witty stories with strong moral lessons and histories of their cultures and people.

Finally, family storytelling emerged as closely aligned with language. Native language served as a mechanism to access the meaning of the family storytelling and, in turn, storytelling functioned as a language sustaining practice. Children aspired to retain and develop mother tongues and described the instrumental role storytelling plays in keeping the language. Several children in the study were losing

native languages, which has strong implications for cultural sustainability. In addition, loss of language may impede children's ability to communicate with their support networks, which is essential for self-reliance upon displacement from the country of origin (Slaughter et al., 2017). "Refugees' livelihoods often operate on familial and community levels," which requires shared language knowledge (Slaughter et al., 2017, p. 3). Children in this study also articulated high hopes for language retention to contribute to positive change in the country of origin. Sustaining language of family storytelling has high stakes for cultural continuation and well-being upon resettlement.

(Dis)connected storytelling practices between family and school

Our findings hinted at the presence of culturally irrelevant stories at school (e.g., about "past" vs. "pets"), which in some cases related to less engagement and participation in school storytelling. However, capturing children's attention alone is not sufficient to move toward culturally sustaining pedagogies. In this study, children from refugee backgrounds noticed the importance of context with their family storytelling that would make a simple inclusion of culturally representative texts insufficient. Children clearly communicated how peers will not be able to understand the story as well because they are unfamiliar with the culture where it unfolds. The literacy research community has been rightfully urging educators to incorporate culturally relevant children's literature into the classroom (Sharma & Christ, 2017). Listening to the voices of our participants, we are learning that, as challenging as this task alone may be, even more work is needed. Despite good intentions, a classroom filled with books from different countries of refugees' origin may promote frozen-in-time and decontextualized texts. Similarly, De Bruijn (2017) argues that teachers should not focus only on "issues of textual representation, but also on children's active intercultural participation" in the contextualized meaning making (p. 1).

Interestingly, though all children expressed the desire to share family storytelling at school, none of them has done so, citing language differences between the two contexts. The necessity of translating stories into English prevented them from retelling stories at school. Although children named language as the barrier to sharing the stories, this is not the full story. The majority of children in the study would be considered bilingual and sufficiently competent in both languages to translate a story from one language into another. In fact, children were sharing English stories they heard at school with their parents (e.g., "I'll tell my mom ... because she might like it. I like her to learn it because she won't know English very well"). This practice is called "cultural brokering" (Jones, Trickett, & Birman, 2012) and demonstrates how children bring home the language and culture they are learning at school.

Beneath the obvious cultural irrelevance of texts and practices, children in this study made deep connections between family and school literacies, applied cross-cultural literacy strategies, and used complex cognitive processes underlying meaning making. With all the ingenuity that children demonstrated in using literacy strategies across contexts, why was not knowing some exact words in English (e.g., "bamboo") or pronouncing something less accurately perceived as a major road-block? This perception of one-sided communication (we can tell school stories at home, but not family stories at school) may be perpetuating language loss in communities of resettled refugees.

Although peers and teachers made children in our study feel welcome, the system as a whole pushed back through a nonresponsive curriculum (Hollins, 2015) and by not valuing native languages enough for children to apply their ingenuity to break language barriers (Paris & Alim, 2017). The largely one-directional irreversible process of assimilation is one of the reasons families from refugee backgrounds have to fight harder against marginalization (Strekalova-Hughes et al., 2018, 2017). Although losing language and related access to culture, "children are at risk of undergoing downward assimilation, thus labeled because learning of American ways would not lead in this case to upward mobility but exactly to the opposite" such as associated decline in educational and occupational achievement (Haller et al., 2011, p. 737).

Implications for research and practice

As researchers of storytelling in families from refugee backgrounds, we need to keep in mind that children's experiences of storytelling agentially interact with cultural and structural changes after their families leave countries and communities of origin. Their storytelling will never be as static as published texts that freeze in time traditional folklore, nor as essentialized as a universal "refugee journey" story that does no justice to individual pain and suffering. Our work as researchers is to study storytelling as a combination of tradition and children's own experiences in culturally and structurally different contexts.

We found that children and families value intergenerational storytelling, which has important implications for anyone developing culturally sustaining pedagogies for children from refugee backgrounds—the need to curricularize their family storytelling. Our findings offered several suggestions to keep in mind when curricularizing intergenerational storytelling of refugee families.

The first suggestion informs selection of classroom literature and stories related to children from refugee backgrounds. Because children's literature about refugees often focuses on their legal protective status and its direct consequences, teachers need to work with families to identify stories that families want to curricularize and sustain, rather than stories that outsiders tell about a "universal" refugee experience. Second, beyond selecting the "right" stories, educators need to keep in mind that different ways of sharing stories engage different cognitive processes and inform cultural integrity of storytelling practices. What we should aim to nurture and sustain in classrooms are culturally unique aspects in the way storytelling are told (e.g., remembering, repeated storytelling, and performative variations). For example, teachers could engage in repeated telling of stories from memory modeling explicit motivation to share the stories "with others" and "in the future." Third, for stories to be understood at school, teachers should provide rich cultural context surrounding the stories beyond including token culturally representative texts. Otherwise, it may become a caricature of the culture and promote stereotypes. This work of authentic incorporation of stories' context is impossible without teachers' collaboration with families and communities as learners who willingly decenter their own culture in the classroom.

It appears that given the opportunity, the children from refugee backgrounds are ready to share their stories at school and are eager to develop their multiple languages further. Their literacy skills and diverse cultural and experiential backgrounds are available to be transformative for the classroom if teachers can imagine possibilities beyond commonplace practice. Moving to culturally and linguistically sustaining pedagogy that values cultural democracy may start breaking the language and contextual barriers similar to the ones children in this study perceived. In addition, teachers can show the value of all languages by teaching literacy strategies across cultures and languages. Children are already using strategies they learn at school to decode storytelling at home (e.g., context clues). Teachers could make these strategies more explicitly relevant to different languages and motivate children to provide examples from languages they speak. In addition, teachers can collaborate with families and communities to learn and incorporate culturally responsive literacy strategies into school practices to communicate the value of refugee students' backgrounds.

Finally, given the intersectional diversity of families from refugee backgrounds, the task of culturally sustaining teaching may be too overwhelming to place on teachers alone. Researchers, especially at urban institutions serving cities with high refugee populations, must engage in community-based research service projects in collaboration with families and community leaders. Their research should aim to support local teachers engaging in culturally sustaining pedagogies with diverse children from refugee backgrounds in their communities. These efforts will start building contextualized evolving repertoires of storytelling practices to authentically inform culturally sustaining pedagogy for children from refugee backgrounds in local classrooms, school districts, and other educational settings.

Conclusion

Before developing culturally sustaining pedagogies for children from refugee backgrounds, we need to know what cultural practices remain important to the communities in the midst of ongoing and ever-shifting dynamic cultural evolutions (Paris & Alim, 2017). This study revealed that children from refugee Nepali, Somali, and South Sudanese communities continue to value family storytelling. Specifically, children rely on the wealth of family stories that teach important moral lessons and cultural histories in witty, humorous, and overall engaging and entertaining ways. Children apply these lessons to their lives and aspire to carry them forward. This is a powerful counternarrative to the external stories about refugees that hyperbolize identities attached to the legal protective refugee status (i.e., violence, fear, inability to return home) (Strekalova-Hughes et al., 2018, 2017).

To inform culturally sustaining practices at school, we also need to know the unique cultural aspects within family storytelling practices and honor them in our efforts to sustain these cultures. From this study, we learned that children from refugee backgrounds can be a powerful resource in identifying how exactly the cultural practices differ between contexts (e.g., remembering, repeated storytelling, performance) to inform culturally sustaining pedagogy. In addition, our findings suggest that within the external assimilation pressures, children persevere and make powerful connections between home and school literacy practices and apply cross-cultural literacy strategies that can benefit development of culturally sustaining pedagogical practices at school. Further research can benefit from exploring how such cross-cultural literacy connections can be utilized at local educational settings to sustain meaningful and culturally specific aspects of family storytelling within diverse and evolving communities from refugee backgrounds. Finally, though the focus of this study was on storytelling, participating families practiced diversity of other intergenerational literacy practices (e.g., creating and solving riddles, singing together, literacy events associated with religious and spiritual practices) that may need further research attention to enrich culturally sustaining pedagogy for this population of students.

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